Linear Algebra - Comprehensive Course Notes (MATH 205)

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1. Linear Equations & Systems

A **linear equation** in n variables takes the form: $a_1x_1 + a_2x_2 + \cdots + a_nx_n = b$. All variables must be to the first power. No products of variables (like xy), and no functions of variables (like $\sqrt{x}$ or $\sin(x)$).

A **System of Linear Equations** is a set of these equations. We classify systems by their solutions:

- **Consistent:** The system has *at least one* solution.
- **Inconsistent:** The system has *no solution* at all.
- **Homogeneous:** The equations all equal zero ($Ax = \mathbf{0}$). It is *always consistent* because $x = \mathbf{0}$ is always a solution (the "trivial solution").
- **Non-Homogeneous:** The equations equal constants ($Ax = \mathbf{b}$).

The Matrix Form ($Ax = b$)

Any system of linear equations can be rewritten cleanly into a single matrix equation $Ax = b$. For example, given the system:

$$\begin{cases} 2x_1 + 3x_2 = 5 \\ 4x_1 - 1x_2 = 6 \end{cases}$$

We map the components directly into matrices:

- A **(The Coefficient Matrix):** Contains all the numbers attached to the variables.

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 3 \\ 4 & -1 \end{bmatrix}$$

- x **(The Unknown Variable Matrix):** A column vector containing the variables we are trying to solve for.

$$x = \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \end{bmatrix}$$

- b **(The Constants Matrix):** A column vector containing the answers on the right-most part of the equation.

$$b = \begin{bmatrix} 5 \\ 6 \end{bmatrix}$$

Putting it all together, $Ax = b$ looks exactly like this:

$$\begin{bmatrix} 2 & 3 \\ 4 & -1 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 5 \\ 6 \end{bmatrix}$$

The Geometry of Solutions (2D)

When analyzing a system of two variables, the equations represent lines in a 2D plane:

1. **Intersecting Lines (Unique Solution):** The lines cross at exactly one point (x_1, x_2). Consistent.

2. **Parallel Lines (Zero Solutions):** The lines have the same slope but different intercepts. They never cross. Inconsistent.
3. **Coincident Lines (Infinitely Many Solutions):** One equation is just a multiple of the other (e.g., $x + y = 1$ and $2x + 2y = 2$). They represent the exact same line drawn twice. Consistent.

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2. Matrix Fundamentals

What is a Matrix?

A rectangular array of numbers enclosed in brackets.

- **Order (Size):** Always described as **Rows** $\times$ **Columns**.
  - *Example:* $\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 5 & 6 \end{bmatrix}$ has 2 rows and 3 columns. It is a 2×3 matrix.
- **Equality:** Two matrices are equal ($A = B$) ONLY if they have the exact same size AND corresponding entries match perfectly.
  - *Example:* $\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix} \neq \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 4 & 3 \end{bmatrix}$ (entries don't match).
- **Row/Column Vectors:** A matrix with only one column ($m \times 1$) or one row ($1 \times n$).
  - *Example:* $\begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 2 \\ 3 \end{bmatrix}$ is a column vector (3×1). $\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \end{bmatrix}$ is a row vector (1×3).

Basic Operations & Properties

- **Addition ($A + B$):** Must be the exact same size. Add entry-wise.
  - *Example:* $\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix} + \begin{bmatrix} 5 & 6 \\ 7 & 8 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 6 & 8 \\ 10 & 12 \end{bmatrix}$
- **Scalar Multiplication (cA):** Multiply every entry by c.
  - *Example:* $3 \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 6 \\ 9 & 12 \end{bmatrix}$

> **Theorem 1.4.1 (Properties of Matrix Arithmetic)**
>
> Assuming matrix sizes permit the operations, the following familiar laws hold:
>
> - **Commutative Law for Addition:** $A + B = B + A$
> - **Associative Laws:** $A + (B + C) = (A + B) + C$ and $A(BC) = (AB)C$
> - **Distributive Laws:** $A(B + C) = AB + AC$ and $(B + C)A = BA + CA$

(Note: Scalar multiplication also distributes intuitively over addition and subtraction: $a(B \pm C) = aB \pm aC$, and scalars can be pulled out of matrix multiplication: $a(BC) = (aB)C = B(aC)$).

Special Matrices

- **The Zero (Null) Matrix (O or 0):** A matrix where every entry is 0.
  - *Example:* $O = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$

> **Theorem 1.4.2 (Properties of Zero Matrices)**

> Assuming sizes allow operations:
>
> - $A + 0 = 0 + A = A$
> - $A - A = 0$
> - $0 - A = -A$
> - $A0 = 0$ and $0A = 0$

- **Diagonal Matrix:** A square matrix where every entry *off* the main diagonal is zero.
  - *Example:* $\begin{bmatrix} 5 & 0 \\ 0 & -2 \end{bmatrix}$
- **The Identity Matrix (I):** A diagonal matrix with \$1\$s on the main diagonal. $diag(1, 1, \ldots, 1)$. Multiplying by it changes nothing: $AI = IA = A$.
  - *Example:* $I_3 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$
- **Transpose (A^T):** Flips rows and columns over the main diagonal.
  - *Example:* If $A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 5 & 6 \end{bmatrix}$, then $A^T = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 4 \\ 2 & 5 \\ 3 & 6 \end{bmatrix}$

> Theorem 1.4.9 (Properties of the Transpose)
>
> Assuming sizes allow operations:
>
> - **Double Transpose:** $((A)^T)^T = A$
> - **Addition/Subtraction:** $(A \pm B)^T = A^T \pm B^T$
> - **Scalar Multiplication:** $(kA)^T = kA^T$
> - **Multiplication (Reverse Rule):** $(AB)^T = B^T A^T$ (The order flips, just like inverses!).
> - **Symmetric Matrix:** $A^T = A$. (The main diagonal acts like a mirror).
> - *Example:* $\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 5 \\ 5 & 2 \end{bmatrix}$
> - **Skew-Symmetric Matrix:** $A^T = -A$.
> - *Example:* $\begin{bmatrix} 0 & 2 \\ -2 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$

Proof **(Why the diagonal must be zero):** If $A^T = -A$, then for any entry on the main diagonal a_{ii}, the transpose entry is still a_{ii}.

$$a_{ii} = -a_{ii}$$

$$2a_{ii} = 0$$

$$a_{ii} = 0$$

- **Transpose Proofs & Tricks:**

- Proof **of Theorem 1.4.9(d) ($(AB)^T = B^T A^T$):** Let's verify this for general 2×2 matrices $A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{bmatrix} e & f \\ g & h \end{bmatrix}$. **Left side:**

$$AB = \begin{bmatrix} ae + bg & af + bh \\ ce + dg & cf + dh \end{bmatrix}$$

$$(AB)^T = \begin{bmatrix} ae + bg & ce + dg \\ af + bh & cf + dh \end{bmatrix}$$

Right side:

$$B^T A^T = \begin{bmatrix} e & g \\ f & h \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} a & c \\ b & d \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} ea + gb & ec + gd \\ fa + hb & fc + hd \end{bmatrix}$$

Since multiplication of normal numbers is commutative ($ea = ae$), the left and right sides are perfectly equal!

- **Generalization (n matrices):** The transpose of a product of any number of matrices is equal to the product of their transposes in reverse order:

$$(A_1 A_2 \dots A_n)^T = A_n^T \dots A_2^T A_1^T$$

- Proof **that $A + A^T$ is symmetric:** Take the transpose of the whole expression:

$$(A + A^T)^T = A^T + (A^T)^T$$

$$= A^T + A$$

$$= A + A^T$$

Since it evaluates back to its original self, it is symmetric.

- Proof **that $A - A^T$ is skew-symmetric:** Take the transpose:

$$(A - A^T)^T = A^T - (A^T)^T$$

$$= A^T - A$$

$$= -(A - A^T)$$

Since it evaluates to its own negative, it is skew-symmetric.

- Proof **that AA^T and $A^T A$ are symmetric:** Take the transpose using Theorem 1.4.9(d):

$$(AA^T)^T = (A^T)^T A^T = AA^T \quad (\text{It equals itself!})$$

$$(A^T A)^T = A^T (A^T)^T = A^T A \quad (\text{It equals itself!})$$

3. Matrix Multiplication (AB)

The Compatibility Rule

You can only multiply $A \times B$ if the "inside" dimensions match.

- If A is $(m \times \mathbf{n})$ and B is $(\mathbf{n} \times p)$, they **can** be multiplied.

- The resulting matrix will have the "outside" dimensions: $(m \times p)$.

Example: Row by Column Multiplication

To find an entry in AB, take a row of A and a column of B, multiply matching items, and sum them up (dot product).

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 5 & 6 \end{bmatrix}, \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 7 & 8 \\ 9 & 1 \\ 2 & 3 \end{bmatrix}$$

A is 2×3, B is 3×2. The result $C = AB$ will be 2×2.

- $C_{11} = (1 \cdot 7) + (2 \cdot 9) + (3 \cdot 2) = 7 + 18 + 6 = 31$
- $C_{12} = (1 \cdot 8) + (2 \cdot 1) + (3 \cdot 3) = 8 + 2 + 9 = 19$
- $C_{21} = (4 \cdot 7) + (5 \cdot 9) + (6 \cdot 2) = 28 + 45 + 12 = 85$
- $C_{22} = (4 \cdot 8) + (5 \cdot 1) + (6 \cdot 3) = 32 + 5 + 18 = 55$

$$AB = \begin{bmatrix} 31 & 19 \\ 85 & 55 \end{bmatrix}$$

Crucial Properties

- **Order Matters!** Matrix multiplication is NOT commutative. $AB \neq BA$ (in almost all cases).
  - Proof: **Why** $(A+B)^2 \neq A^2 + B^2 + 2AB$

    $$(A+B)^2 = (A+B)(A+B) = A(A+B) + B(A+B) = A^2 + AB + BA + B^2$$

    Because AB and BA are usually not equal, you cannot combine them into $2AB$. This identity only works if A and B commute!
- **Associative Law:** $A(BC) = (AB)C$.
- **Multiplying by a Diagonal Matrix:** Diagonal matrices act like a set of independent scale factors.
  - **Left multiply (DA):** Scales row i of A by d_i. *Example:* $\begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{2} & 0 \\ 0 & \mathbf{3} \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{2} & \mathbf{2} \\ \mathbf{3} & \mathbf{3} \end{bmatrix}$ (Row 1 doubled, Row 2 tripled).
  - **Right multiply (AE):** Scales column j of A by e_j. *Example:* $\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{2} & 0 \\ 0 & \mathbf{3} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{2} & \mathbf{3} \\ \mathbf{2} & \mathbf{3} \end{bmatrix}$ (Column 1 doubled, Column 2 tripled).
- **The Cancellation Law Does NOT Hold:** In standard arithmetic, if $ab = ac$ and $a \neq 0$, then $b = c$. Also, if $ad = 0$, then either $a = 0$ or $d = 0$. Neither rule applies to matrices!
  - *Example 3:* Let $A = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 2 \end{bmatrix}, B = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix}, C = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 5 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix}, D = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 7 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$. Notice that $AB = AC = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 4 \\ 6 & 8 \end{bmatrix}$. Even though $A \neq 0$, we cannot "cancel" A to conclude $B = C$ (since $B \neq C$). Furthermore, $AD = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix} = 0$. The product is zero, yet neither A nor D are zero matrices!

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4. Inverses & Determinants

Inverse Matrices (A^{-1})

- **Definition:** If Q and A are square matrices of the same order n, Q is an inverse of A if and only if:

$$QA = AQ = I_n = I \iff Q = A^{-1}$$

- **Nonsingular / Invertible:** A has an inverse.
- **Singular:** No inverse of A exists.

> **Theorem 1.4.4 (Uniqueness of Inverse)**
>
> If B and C are both inverses of the matrix A, then $B = C$.

Proof: Since B is an inverse of A, we have $BA = I$. Multiplying both sides on the right by C:

$$(BA)C = IC = C$$

By the Associative Law, we can regroup the left side: $(BA)C = B(AC)$. Since C is also an inverse of A, we know $AC = I$. Substituting this in gives:

$$B(AC) = B(I) = B$$

Because $(BA)C$ evaluates to C (from the first step) and B (from the second step), we conclude $\therefore C = B$.

> **Theorem 1.4.6 (Inverse of a Product / The Reverse Rule)**
>
> If A and B are invertible matrices of the same size, then $(AB)^{-1} = B^{-1}A^{-1}$. Notice the order flips!

Proof: To verify $B^{-1}A^{-1}$ is the true inverse of AB, we multiply them together to see if they simplify down to I:

$$(AB)(B^{-1}A^{-1}) = A(BB^{-1})A^{-1} = AIA^{-1} = AA^{-1} = I$$

$$(B^{-1}A^{-1})(AB) = B^{-1}(A^{-1}A)B = B^{-1}IB = B^{-1}B = I$$

Since both left and right multiplication result in I, it is proven!

- **Generalization (n matrices):** A product of any number of invertible matrices is invertible. The inverse of the product is the product of the inverses, *in reverse order*.

$$(A_1A_2 \dots A_n)^{-1} = A_n^{-1}A_{n-1}^{-1} \dots A_2^{-1}A_1^{-1}$$

> **Theorem 1.4.7 & 1.4.8 (Laws of Exponents for Matrices)**
>
> If A is a square matrix and r, s are integers, standard exponent laws apply: $A^rA^s = A^{r+s}$ and $(A^r)^s = A^{rs}$. Furthermore, if A is *invertible*, the following holds:
>
> - **(a) The Inverse of an Inverse:** $(A^{-1})^{-1} = A$.
> - **(b) Powers of Inverses:** $(A^n)^{-1} = (A^{-1})^n$ for $n = 0, 1, 2, \dots$
> - **(c) Scalar Multiplication:** For any nonzero scalar k, $(kA)^{-1} = \frac{1}{k}A^{-1}$.

Proof **(a):** By definition, we need a matrix that multiplies with A^{-1} to give I.

$$AA^{-1} = I \quad \text{and} \quad A^{-1}A = I$$

Since A perfectly satisfies the condition to be the inverse of A^{-1}, then $(A^{-1})^{-1} = A$.

Proof **(b):** Let's post-multiply A^n by $(A^{-1})^n$ to see if they collapse into I:

$$A^n(A^{-1})^n = (\underbrace{A \dots A}_{n})(\underbrace{A^{-1} \dots A^{-1}}_{n})$$

$$= A \dots A(AA^{-1})A^{-1} \dots A^{-1}$$

$$= A \dots A(I)A^{-1} \dots A^{-1} = I$$

(The chain cascades and cancels from the inside out. The same happens for pre-multiplication, proving it is the inverse).

> **Theorem 1.4.10 (Invertibility of a Transpose)**
>
> If A is invertible, then its transpose A^T is also invertible, and $(A^T)^{-1} = (A^{-1})^T$.

Proof: By definition, if $(A^{-1})^T$ is truly the inverse of A^T, then multiplying them must equal I. Let's multiply them, and use the transpose property $(AB)^T = B^T A^T$ to pull the T outside:

$$A^T(A^{-1})^T = (A^{-1}A)^T = I^T = I$$

$$(A^{-1})^T A^T = (AA^{-1})^T = I^T = I$$

Both equations simplify to I, so $(A^{-1})^T$ is indeed the inverse!

> **Theorem 1.6.3 (One-Sided Inverse Theorem)**
>
> Let A be a square matrix. If another square matrix B satisfies $BA = I$, then $B = A^{-1}$. (Similarly, if $AB = I$, then $B = A^{-1}$). This means for square matrices, you only need to check *one* side to confirm it's the true inverse!

Proof: Given $BA = I$, we can use Theorem 1.5.3 (The Master Theorem) to show A is invertible. Let x_0 be any solution to $Ax = 0$. Left-multiply both sides of $Ax_0 = 0$ by B:

$$B(Ax_0) = B(0)$$

$$(BA)x_0 = 0$$

$$Ix_0 = 0$$

$$x_0 = 0$$

Since $Ax = 0$ yields only the trivial solution $x_0 = 0$, the Master Theorem guarantees that A is invertible (meaning A^{-1} exists). Knowing A^{-1} exists, we can post-multiply our original given equation ($BA = I$) by A^{-1}:

$$(BA)A^{-1} = IA^{-1}$$

$$B(AA^{-1}) = A^{-1}$$

$$B(I) = A^{-1}$$

$$B = A^{-1}$$

Introduction to Determinants

(Note: We will explore determinants deeply in upcoming lectures. For now, here are the absolute basics needed for inverses).

> **Theorem 1.4.5 (The 2 x 2 Inverse Formula)**
>
> For a 2×2 matrix $A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$:
>
> - Calculate the **Determinant**: $\det(A) = ad - bc$.
> - If $\det(A) = 0$, the matrix is **Singular** (no inverse).
> - If $\det(A) \neq 0$, the matrix is **Nonsingular** (invertible), and the inverse is:
>
> $$A^{-1} = \frac{1}{\det(A)} \begin{bmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{bmatrix}$$
>
> *(Swap the main diagonal entries, and flip the signs of the off-diagonal entries).*

2. Determinant of a Diagonal Matrix If a matrix is diagonal, finding its determinant is incredibly easy: just multiply all the entries on the main diagonal together.

- *Example:* If $D = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -3 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 5 \end{bmatrix}$, then $\det(D) = (2)(-3)(5) = -30$.
- *Trick:* Because of this, a diagonal matrix is invertible if and only if *every single entry* on its main diagonal is non-zero (otherwise the product/determinant would be 0).

---

5. Elementary Matrices & The Master Theorem

Elementary Row Operations (EROs) & Elementary Matrices

To solve any system, we manipulate its matrix using three "legal" moves called **EROs**:

1. **Scaling:** Multiply a row by a nonzero constant.
2. **Swapping:** Interchange two rows.
3. **Replacement:** Add a multiple of one row to another.

Elementary Matrices (E): An elementary matrix is formed by applying exactly *one* ERO to the Identity Matrix I.

- *The Magic Trick:* Applying an ERO to a matrix A by hand produces the exact same result as left-multiplying that matrix by E.
- *Example (Swapping Rows):* Let's swap Row 1 and Row 2 of $A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$. If we swap rows on the Identity matrix I, we get our elementary matrix $E = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$. Now, watch the multiplication: $EA = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} c & d \\ a & b \end{bmatrix}$. The rows swapped!

> **Theorem 1.4.3 (RREF of a Square Matrix)**

> If R is the reduced row-echelon form of an $n \times n$ matrix A, then either R has a row of zeros or R is the identity matrix I_n. *(Note: If R is I_n, A is invertible. If R has a row of zeros, A is singular).*

> **Theorem 1.5.2 (Invertibility of Elementary Matrices)**
>
> Every elementary matrix is invertible, and the inverse is also an elementary matrix.

> **Theorem 1.5.3 (Equivalent Statements / The "Master Theorem")**
>
> If A is an $n \times n$ matrix, the following statements are completely equivalent (they are all true, or all false):
>
> - **(a)** A is invertible.
> - **(b)** $Ax = 0$ has only the trivial solution ($x = 0$).
> - **(c)** The reduced row-echelon form (RREF) of A is I_n.
> - **(d)** A is expressible as a product of elementary matrices.

Proof **(The Chain of Implications):** We prove they are equivalent by showing $(a) \implies (b) \implies (c) \implies (d) \implies (a)$.

- $(a) \implies (b)$**:** Assume A is invertible. Let x_0 be any solution to the equation $Ax_0 = 0$. Left-multiply both sides by A^{-1}:

$$A^{-1}(Ax_0) = A^{-1}0$$

$$(A^{-1}A)x_0 = 0$$

$$Ix_0 = 0 \implies x_0 = 0$$

  Thus, only the trivial solution exists.
- $(b) \implies (c)$**:** Assume $Ax = 0$ has only the trivial solution. If we write this as an augmented matrix $[A|0]$ and row reduce it, the only solution being $x_1 = 0, x_2 = 0 \dots x_n = 0$ means the final RREF equations are exactly:

$$x_1 = 0, \quad x_2 = 0, \quad \dots \quad x_n = 0$$

  This means the RREF matrix looks like $[I_n|0]$. If we drop the zero column, this proves the RREF of A itself is exactly I_n.
- $(c) \implies (d)$**:** Assume the RREF of A is I_n. This means a sequence of elementary row operations turns A into I_n. Let $E_1, E_2 \dots E_k$ be their corresponding elementary matrices:

$$E_k \dots E_2 E_1 A = I_n$$

  Because every elementary matrix is invertible, we multiply both sides by their inverses to isolate A:

$$A = E_1^{-1} E_2^{-1} \dots E_k^{-1} I_n$$

$$A = E_1^{-1} E_2^{-1} \dots E_k^{-1}$$

  Since the inverse of an elementary matrix is just another elementary matrix, A is successfully expressed as a product of elementary matrices!

- $(d) \implies (a)$**:** Assume A is a product of elementary matrices. Since every elementary matrix is invertible, A is simply a product of invertible matrices. By Theorem 1.4.6, a product of invertible matrices is always invertible! Thus, A is invertible, and the chain is complete.

> **Theorem 1.6.1 (Number of Solutions to a Linear System)**
>
> Every system of linear equations has no solutions, or has exactly one solution, or has infinitely many solutions.

Proof: The proof is complete if we can show that a system with more than one solution must automatically have infinitely many solutions. Assume $Ax = b$ has more than one solution. Let x_1 and x_2 be two *distinct* solutions. Since they are solutions, we know:

$$Ax_1 = b \quad \text{and} \quad Ax_2 = b$$

Let's define a new vector $x_0 = x_1 - x_2$. Because x_1 and x_2 are distinct, $x_0 \neq 0$. Now, let's multiply A by x_0:

$$Ax_0 = A(x_1 - x_2) = Ax_1 - Ax_2 = b - b = 0$$

So, $Ax_0 = 0$. Now, let k be any arbitrary scalar constant. Let's test if a new vector $x = x_1 + kx_0$ is a solution:

$$A(x_1 + kx_0) = Ax_1 + A(kx_0)$$

$$= Ax_1 + k(Ax_0)$$

Substitute in what we know ($Ax_1 = b$ and $Ax_0 = 0$):

$$= b + k(0)$$

$$= b$$

Because $A(x_1 + kx_0) = b$, the vector $x_1 + kx_0$ is a valid solution! Since k can be *any* real number, there are infinitely many values for $x_1 + kx_0$. Thus, the system has infinitely many solutions.

> **Theorem 1.6.2 (Solving Linear Systems with Inverses)**
>
> If A is an invertible $n \times n$ matrix, then for each $n \times 1$ matrix b, the system of equations $Ax = b$ has exactly one solution, namely $x = A^{-1}b$.

Proof: Since $A(A^{-1}b) = (AA^{-1})b = Ib = b$, it follows that $x = A^{-1}b$ is a valid solution of $Ax = b$. To show that this is the *only* solution, we will assume that x_0 is an arbitrary solution and then show that x_0 must equal $A^{-1}b$. If x_0 is any solution, then $Ax_0 = b$. Left-multiplying both sides by A^{-1}, we obtain:

$$A^{-1}(Ax_0) = A^{-1}b$$

$$(A^{-1}A)x_0 = A^{-1}b$$

$$Ix_0 = A^{-1}b$$

$$x_0 = A^{-1}b$$

This proves $x = A^{-1}b$ is the unique solution.

Theorem 1.6.4 (Equivalent Statements / Continuation of Master Theorem)

This theorem incorporates Determinants into the Master Theorem, adding statement (g). If A is an $n \times n$ matrix, then the following are equivalent:

- **(a)** A is invertible.
- **(b)** $Ax = 0$ has only the trivial solution.
- **(c)** The reduced row-echelon form of A is I_n.
- **(d)** A is expressible as a product of elementary matrices.
- **(e)** $Ax = b$ is consistent for every $n \times 1$ matrix b.
- **(f)** $Ax = b$ has exactly one solution for every $n \times 1$ matrix b.

Proof: Since we proved in Theorem 1.5.3 that (a), (b), (c), and (d) are equivalent, it is sufficient to prove that $(a) \implies (f) \implies (e) \implies (a)$.

- $(a) \implies (f)$**:** This was already proved in Theorem 1.6.2 (If A is invertible, there is exactly one solution $x = A^{-1}b$).
- $(f) \implies (e)$**:** This is self-evident. If $Ax = b$ has exactly one solution, then by definition it must be consistent.
- $(e) \implies (a)$**:** If $Ax = b$ is consistent for every possible b, then in particular, the following n systems are all consistent:

$$Ax = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ \dots \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}, \quad Ax = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ \dots \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \dots, \quad Ax = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ \dots \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

Let $x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n$ be the respective solutions of these systems. Let us form an $n \times n$ matrix C using these solution vectors as its columns: $C = [x_1|x_2|\dots|x_n]$. As discussed in matrix multiplication rules (column-by-column), the successive columns of the product AC will be $Ax_1, Ax_2, \dots, Ax_n$. Thus:

$$AC = [Ax_1|Ax_2|\dots|Ax_n] = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & \dots & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & \dots & 0 \\ \dots & \dots & \dots & \dots \\ 0 & 0 & \dots & 1 \end{bmatrix} = I$$

By Theorem 1.6.3 (One-Sided Inverse), since $AC = I$, it follows that $C = A^{-1}$. Thus, A is invertible!

Theorem 1.6.5 (Invertibility of a Product)

Let A and B be square matrices of the same size. If AB is invertible, then A and B must also be invertible.

Proof: Since AB is invertible, it has an inverse, let's call it C. By the definition of an inverse, multiplying AB by C yields the identity matrix I:

$$(AB)C = I \quad \text{and} \quad C(AB) = I$$

Using the associative property of matrix multiplication, we can regroup these equations:

$$A(BC) = I \quad \text{and} \quad (CA)B = I$$

By **Theorem 1.6.3 (One-Sided Inverse Theorem)**, if a square matrix can be multiplied by another matrix to yield I, then it is invertible.

- Since $A(BC) = I$, the matrix BC acts as the inverse of A. Thus, A is invertible.
- Since $(CA)B = I$, the matrix CA acts as the inverse of B. Thus, B is invertible. Therefore, both A and B must be invertible.

---

6. Methods for Solving Systems ($Ax = b$)

There are three primary methods for solving systems, each with a specific use case:

Method 1: The Inverse Method (Using $[A|I]$)

Best for: Solving *many* different systems that all share the exact same coefficient matrix A, but have different answers b. Once you find A^{-1}, you can just compute $x = A^{-1}b$ repeatedly.

1. Setup the augmented matrix: $[A|I]$
2. Apply EROs until the left side perfectly matches the Identity Matrix.
3. The result on the right is your inverse: $[I|A^{-1}]$.

Worked Example: Find the inverse of $A = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 4 \\ 1 & 3 \end{bmatrix}$.

- **Step 1 (Setup):** $\left[\begin{array}{cc|cc} 2 & 4 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 3 & 0 & 1 \end{array}\right]$
- **Step 2 (Swap R1 & R2 to get a leading 1):** $\left[\begin{array}{cc|cc} 1 & 3 & 0 & 1 \\ 2 & 4 & 1 & 0 \end{array}\right]$
- **Step 3 ($R_2 \leftarrow R_2 - 2R_1$):** $\left[\begin{array}{cc|cc} 1 & 3 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & -2 & 1 & -2 \end{array}\right]$
- **Step 4 ($R_2 \leftarrow R_2 \div -2$):** $\left[\begin{array}{cc|cc} 1 & 3 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & -0.5 & 1 \end{array}\right]$
- **Step 5 ($R_1 \leftarrow R_1 - 3R_2$):** $\left[\begin{array}{cc|cc} 1 & 0 & 1.5 & -2 \\ 0 & 1 & -0.5 & 1 \end{array}\right]$
- **Result:** $A^{-1} = \begin{bmatrix} 1.5 & -2 \\ -0.5 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$.

Proof: **Why does this method work?** Suppose $\theta_1, \theta_2, \ldots, \theta_k$ are the EROs that turn an invertible matrix A into I, with corresponding elementary matrices $E_1, E_2, \ldots, E_k$. Applying them one after another to A:

$$\theta_k \ldots \theta_2 \theta_1(A) = E_k \ldots E_2 E_1 A = I$$

Writing P for the product of all those elementary matrices, we get the seed equation:

$$PA = I \quad \text{where} \quad P = E_k \ldots E_2 E_1$$

Since A is invertible, multiply both sides of $PA = I$ on the right by A^{-1}:

$$PAA^{-1} = IA^{-1}$$

$$PI = A^{-1}$$

$$P = A^{-1}$$

This proves that P (the exact same chain of row operations applied to the Identity matrix) equals the inverse! That's why $[A|I]$ becomes $[I|A^{-1}]$.

Method 2: Gaussian Elimination (Row-Echelon Form - REF)

Best for: Solving a *single* system quickly by hand. You set up an augmented matrix $[A|b]$ and use EROs to create a "staircase" pattern known as **Row-Echelon Form (REF)**.

- **The Rules of REF:**
  1. Rows of all zeros must be at the very bottom.
  2. The first non-zero number in a row must be a 1 (called a "leading 1").
  3. Each leading 1 must be further to the right than the leading 1 in the row above it.
- *Example of REF:*

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} \mathbf{1} & 2 & 3 & 9 \\ 0 & \mathbf{1} & 4 & 5 \\ 0 & 0 & \mathbf{1} & 2 \end{array}\right]$$

- **Next step:** Stop here, convert back to equations (e.g., the bottom row means $1z = 2$), and use **back-substitution** to find the rest of the variables.
  - **Worked Example (Back-Substitution):** Using the REF matrix above:
    - Row 3: $z = 2$
    - Row 2: $y + 4z = 5 \implies y + 4(2) = 5 \implies y = -3$
    - Row 1: $x + 2y + 3z = 9 \implies x + 2(-3) + 3(2) = 9 \implies x = 9$
    - **Solution:** $(9, -3, 2)$

Method 3: Gauss-Jordan Elimination (Reduced Row-Echelon Form - RREF)

Best for: Solving a *single* system completely so the matrix hands you the answers directly, with zero algebra required at the end. You take your REF matrix one step further into **Reduced Row-Echelon Form (RREF)**.

- **The Rules of RREF:**
  1. It must meet all the rules of REF (the staircase of leading 1s).
  2. **Crucial Addition:** Each leading 1 (pivot) must be the *only* non-zero number in its entire column. You must create zeros both ABOVE and BELOW every pivot.
- **Worked Example (Continuing from REF to RREF):** Let's take the REF matrix from Method 2 and turn it into RREF by clearing the numbers *above* the pivots.
  - *Start (REF):* $\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 2 & 3 & 9 \\ 0 & 1 & 4 & 5 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{array}\right]$
  - *Step 1 (Clear above z-pivot: $R_2 \leftarrow R_2 - 4R_3$ and $R_1 \leftarrow R_1 - 3R_3$):* $\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 2 & 0 & 3 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -3 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{array}\right]$
  - *Step 2 (Clear above y-pivot: $R_1 \leftarrow R_1 - 2R_2$):* $\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 9 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -3 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{array}\right]$
  - *Result:* The matrix is in RREF. The solution is exactly $(9, -3, 2)$ without doing any algebra on paper!

How Many Solutions? Three Possibilities (via RREF)

A **Pivot** is the leading 1 in a row in RREF. By looking at the pivot columns in an augmented matrix $[A|b]$, you can instantly determine which of the exactly 3 possibilities holds:

1. Unique Solution: Every non-augmented column is a pivot column. *Example:*

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & a \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & b \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & c \end{array}\right] \implies \begin{cases} x = a \\ y = b \\ z = c \end{cases}$$

2. Infinitely Many Solutions: The last column is not a pivot, AND at least one other column is not a pivot column (i.e. there is at least 1 free variable). *Example:*

$$\left[\begin{array}{cccc|c} 1 & -2 & 0 & 3 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 4 & -1 \end{array}\right]$$

(Columns 2 and 4 lack pivots, so they are free variables).

3. No Solution: The last (augmented) column is a pivot column. *Example:*

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array}\right] \implies 0 = 1$$

Free Variables & Parametric Form

- **Definition:** A variable x_i is a free variable if its column, in a row-echelon form of the matrix, is not a pivot column.

Recipe: Parametric Form

1. Write the system as an augmented matrix.
2. Row reduce to reduced row-echelon form (RREF).
3. Write the corresponding system of equations.
4. Move all free variables to the right-hand side.

Example (translating RREF to parametric form): Given the RREF matrix: $\left[\begin{array}{ccc|c} 1 & 0 & 5 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & -1 \end{array}\right]$

- **Step 3 (Equations):** $\begin{cases} x + 5z = 1 \\ y + 2z = -1 \end{cases}$
- **Step 4 (Move free variable z to right):** $\begin{cases} x = 1 - 5z \\ y = -1 - 2z \\ z = z \quad (\text{any real number}) \end{cases}$

---

7. Determinants and Their Properties

What is a Determinant? (A Layman's Intro)

Every square matrix acts as a mathematical transformation that can stretch or shrink space. The **determinant**, denoted as $\det(A)$ or $|A|$, is a single scalar number that summarizes exactly how much that matrix scales things.

- If $\det(A) = 2$, the matrix doubles the area/volume of whatever it transforms.
- If $\det(A) = 0$, the matrix completely crushes space flat (which is why a matrix with a determinant of zero has no inverse—you cannot mathematically "un-crush" a flat object!).

Calculating a 2×2 Determinant: For a 2×2 matrix, finding this scaling factor is straightforward. We cross-multiply the diagonals and subtract them:

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\det(A) = ad - bc$$

(Example: For $\begin{bmatrix} 3 & 2 \\ 1 & 4 \end{bmatrix}$, the determinant is $(3)(4) - (2)(1) = 12 - 2 = 10$.)

While calculating the determinant of a 2×2 matrix is simple, expanding larger matrices by hand using brute-force formulas gets highly tedious. Instead, we use an algebraic toolkit of properties that allow us to evaluate and manipulate determinants efficiently.

How Row Operations (EROs) Affect Determinants

Applying an Elementary Row Operation changes the determinant in specific, predictable ways:

1. **Adding Rows (Replacement):** Adding a multiple of one row/col to another leaves the determinant **unchanged**.
   - $R_i \to R_i + kR_j \implies \text{No Change}$
   - *Proof (2×2 case for $C_1 \to C_1 + C_2$):*

     $$\begin{vmatrix} a+b & b \\ c+d & d \end{vmatrix} = (a+b)d - b(c+d) = ad + bd - bc - bd = ad - bc$$

     (The extra terms always cancel out!)
2. **Swapping Rows:** Interchanging two rows/cols **flips the sign** of the determinant.
   - $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j \implies \text{Multiplies det by } -1$
3. **Scaling a Row:** Multiplying a single row/col by a scalar k scales the determinant by k.
   - $R_i \to kR_i \implies \text{Multiplies det by } k$
   - *Proof (2×2 case, factoring k out of the first column):*

     $$\begin{vmatrix} ka & b \\ kc & d \end{vmatrix} = (ka)d - b(kc) = k(ad - bc) = k\det(A)$$

   - *Warning:* Scaling the *entire* $n \times n$ matrix A scales the determinant by k^n, so $\det(kA) = k^n \det(A)$.

> **Theorem 2.2.4 (Determinants of Elementary Matrices)**
>
> This theorem directly links the ERO determinant properties to Elementary Matrices (E). Since an elementary matrix is formed by applying exactly one ERO to the Identity Matrix I_n, and we know

> $\det(I_n) = 1$, we can determine $\det(E)$ instantly:
>
> - **(a)** If E results from multiplying a row of I_n by k, then $\det(E) = k \cdot \det(I_n) = k$.
> - **(b)** If E results from interchanging two rows of I_n, then $\det(E) = -1 \cdot \det(I_n) = -1$.
> - **(c)** If E results from adding a multiple of one row of I_n to another, then $\det(E) = 1 \cdot \det(I_n) = 1$.

Redundancy = Zero

If a matrix has structural redundancy, it represents a "collapsed" system that cannot be inverted. Thus, its determinant is instantly 0. You do not need to do any math if you spot:

1. **Zero Row/Col:** A matrix with a row or column of all zeros has $\det(A) = 0$.
   - *Proof (2×2 case):* $\begin{vmatrix} a & 0 \\ b & 0 \end{vmatrix} = \begin{vmatrix} a & b \\ 0 & 0 \end{vmatrix} = 0$
2. **Identical Rows/Cols:** A matrix with two completely identical rows or columns has $\det(A) = 0$.
   - *Proof (2×2 case with identical columns):* $\begin{vmatrix} a & a \\ b & b \end{vmatrix} = ab - ab = 0$
3. **Proportional Rows/Cols:** A matrix where one row/col is a scalar multiple of another has $\det(A) = 0$.
   - *Example:* Column 2 is exactly twice column 3:

$$\det \begin{bmatrix} -2 & 8 & 4 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 10 & 5 \end{bmatrix} = 0 \quad (C_2 = 2C_3)$$

(Once you spot a proportional pair, you already know the answer is zero—no need to expand anything).

The Big Trap: Addition

Determinants are **NOT** additive.

$$\det(A + B) \neq \det(A) + \det(B)$$

- *Counterexample:* Let $A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 5 \end{bmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ 1 & 3 \end{bmatrix}$. Then $A + B = \begin{bmatrix} 4 & 3 \\ 3 & 8 \end{bmatrix}$.

$$\det(A) = 1, \quad \det(B) = 8, \quad \det(A + B) = 23$$

$$\det(A) + \det(B) = 9 \neq 23$$

The Addition Rule (The One Case Where It Does Add): If matrices A, B, and C differ in only **one row** (say row i), and row i of C equals $(\text{row } i \text{ of } A) + (\text{row } i \text{ of } B)$, then the determinant is additive in that row *alone*.

- *Example:*

$$\begin{vmatrix} a_{11} & a_{12} \\ a_{21} & a_{22} \end{vmatrix} + \begin{vmatrix} a_{11} & a_{12} \\ b_{21} & b_{22} \end{vmatrix} = \begin{vmatrix} a_{11} & a_{12} \\ a_{21} + b_{21} & a_{22} + b_{22} \end{vmatrix}$$

The Multiplicative Properties

Determinants behave very predictably under standard matrix algebra operations:

1. **Products:** $\det(AB) = \det(A)\det(B)$ (for same-size square matrices, see Theorem 2.3.4 below).
2. **Identity:** $\det(I) = 1$ (for an identity matrix of any size).
3. **Inverses:** $\det(A^{-1}) = \frac{1}{\det(A)}$. *(This proves mathematically why $\det(A)$ cannot be 0 for an invertible matrix!).*
4. **Transposes:** $\det(A^T) = \det(A)$. *(Rows and columns are completely interchangeable when calculating a determinant).*
    - *Proof (2×2 case):* Transposing just swaps the off-diagonal entries, which the formula treats symmetrically.

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}, \quad A^T = \begin{bmatrix} a & c \\ b & d \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\det(A) = ad - bc$$

$$\det(A^T) = ad - cb = ad - bc$$

> **Theorem 2.3.4 (Determinant of a Product)**
>
> If A and B are square matrices of the same size, then:
>
> $$\det(AB) = \det(A)\det(B)$$

Proof **(Two Cases):**

- **Case 1 (Suppose A is not invertible):** If A is not invertible, then $\det(A) = 0$. By Theorem 1.6.5, if AB is invertible, then A and B must be invertible. Therefore, if A is not invertible, the product AB is also not invertible. Therefore, $\det(AB) = 0$. Substituting into the formula: $\det(AB) = \det(A)\det(B) \implies 0 = 0 \cdot \det(B) \implies 0 = 0$. (QED for Case 1).
- **Case 2 (Suppose A is invertible):** By the Master Theorem, an invertible matrix A is expressible as a product of elementary matrices:

  $$A = E_1 E_2 \dots E_r \quad -(1)$$

  Now, let's take the determinant of AB:

  $$\det(AB) = \det(E_1 E_2 \dots E_r B)$$

  Using the property that $\det(EB) = \det(E)\det(B)$ for elementary matrices:

  $$\det(AB) = \det(E_1)\det(E_2)\dots\det(E_r)\det(B)$$

  $$\det(AB) = \det(E_1 E_2 \dots E_r)\det(B)$$

  Substitute A back in using (1):

  $$\det(AB) = \det(A)\det(B)$$

Determinants and the Master Theorem

> **Theorem 2.3.3 (Determinant Test for Invertibility)**
>
> A square matrix A is invertible if and only if $\det(A) \neq 0$.

- Proof: Let R be the reduced row-echelon form of A. We can express R as the product of elementary matrices applied to A:

  $$R = E_r \dots E_2 E_1 A$$

  Taking the determinant of both sides (using the multiplication property):

  $$\det(R) = \det(E_r) \dots \det(E_2) \det(E_1) \det(A)$$

  By Theorem 2.2.4, the determinants of elementary matrices are always non-zero. Therefore, $\det(R)$ will be zero if and only if $\det(A)$ is zero.
  - **If A is invertible:** The Master Theorem states $R = I_n$. Since $\det(I_n) = 1 \neq 0$, then $\det(R) \neq 0$, which forces $\det(A) \neq 0$.
  - **If $\det(A) \neq 0$:** This forces $\det(R) \neq 0$. Because $\det(R)$ is not zero, R cannot contain a row of zeros. By Theorem 1.4.3, an RREF matrix without a zero row must be the identity matrix I_n. If $R = I_n$, the Master Theorem states A is invertible.

> **Theorem 2.3.6 (Equivalent Statements / The Master Theorem - Expanded)**
>
> This theorem incorporates Determinants into the Master Theorem, adding statement (g). If A is an $n \times n$ matrix, then the following are equivalent:
>
> - **(a)** A is invertible.
> - **(b)** $Ax = 0$ has only the trivial solution.
> - **(c)** The reduced row-echelon form of A is I_n.
> - **(d)** A is expressible as a product of elementary matrices.
> - **(e)** $Ax = b$ is consistent for every $n \times 1$ matrix b.
> - **(f)** $Ax = b$ has exactly one solution for every $n \times 1$ matrix b.
> - **(g)** $\det(A) \neq 0$.

---

8. Finding Determinants using Cofactor Expansions

To calculate the determinant of a large $n \times n$ matrix, we can recursively break it down into smaller $(n-1) \times (n-1)$ matrices.

Minors and Cofactors

Before we can calculate a full determinant, we need to understand its building blocks: Minors and Cofactors.

Definition (Minors and Cofactors): If A is a square matrix, then the **minor of entry** a_{ij} is denoted by M_{ij} and is defined to be the determinant of the submatrix that remains after the i-th row and j-th column are deleted from A. The number $(-1)^{i+j} M_{ij}$ is denoted by C_{ij} and is called the **cofactor of entry** a_{ij}.

- **The Relationship:** The cofactor and the minor differ only in sign: $C_{ij} = \pm M_{ij}$.
- **The Checkerboard Trick:** A quick way to determine whether to use $+$ or $-$ is to use the "checkerboard" array pattern of signs. You start with a $+$ in the top left and alternate:

$$\begin{bmatrix} + & - & + & - & \dots \\ - & + & - & + & \dots \\ + & - & + & - & \dots \\ \dots & \dots & \dots & \dots & \dots \end{bmatrix}$$

(Example: The entry a_{11} gets a $+$ (since $(-1)^{1+1} = +1$), so $C_{11} = M_{11}$. The entry a_{32} gets a $-$ (since $(-1)^{3+2} = -1$), so $C_{32} = -M_{32}$.)

Worked Example: Finding Minors and Cofactors Let $A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 1 & -4 \\ 2 & 5 & 6 \\ 1 & 4 & 8 \end{bmatrix}$.

1. **Finding M_{11} and C_{11}:** Cross out Row 1 and Column 1. The remaining submatrix is $\begin{bmatrix} 5 & 6 \\ 4 & 8 \end{bmatrix}$.

$$M_{11} = \det \begin{bmatrix} 5 & 6 \\ 4 & 8 \end{bmatrix} = (5)(8) - (6)(4) = 40 - 24 = 16$$

Since $(1, 1)$ is a $+$ on the checkerboard, $C_{11} = M_{11} = 16$.

2. **Finding M_{32} and C_{32}:** Cross out Row 3 and Column 2. The remaining submatrix is $\begin{bmatrix} 3 & -4 \\ 2 & 6 \end{bmatrix}$.

$$M_{32} = \det \begin{bmatrix} 3 & -4 \\ 2 & 6 \end{bmatrix} = (3)(6) - (-4)(2) = 18 + 8 = 26$$

Since $(3, 2)$ is a $-$ on the checkerboard, $C_{32} = -M_{32} = -26$.

> **Theorem 2.1.1 (Expansions by Cofactors)**
>
> The determinant of an $n \times n$ matrix A can be computed by multiplying the entries in **any** row (or column) by their cofactors and adding the resulting products.
>
> - **Expansion along the i-th row:**
>
> $$\det(A) = a_{i1}C_{i1} + a_{i2}C_{i2} + \cdots + a_{in}C_{in}$$
>
> - **Expansion along the j-th column:**
>
> $$\det(A) = a_{1j}C_{1j} + a_{2j}C_{2j} + \cdots + a_{nj}C_{nj}$$

Strategy: "Smart Choice" of Row or Column Because the theorem guarantees that *any* row or column will yield the correct determinant, you should always choose the row or column containing the **most zeros**. Since $0 \times C_{ij} = 0$, hunting for zeros allows you to entirely skip calculating massive sub-determinants, drastically pruning the recursive calculation tree.

Worked Example: Smart Choice on a 4×4 Matrix Let $A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 & 2 \\ 1 & 0 & -2 & 1 \\ 2 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$.

1. **Step 1:** Look for the most zeros. Column 2 is almost entirely zeros (`0, 1, 0, 0`). We expand along Column 2:

$$\det(A) = (0 \cdot C_{12}) + (1 \cdot C_{22}) + (0 \cdot C_{32}) + (0 \cdot C_{42})$$

Because of the zeros, the problem collapses instantly to just $1 \cdot C_{22}$.

- The entry is 1.
- The sign for position $(2,2)$ is $+$ (since $(-1)^{2+2} = +1$).
- Cross out Row 2 and Column 2 to get the 3×3 minor.

$$\det(A) = +1 \begin{vmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 1 & -2 & 1 \\ 2 & 0 & 1 \end{vmatrix}$$

2. **Step 2:** We now have a 3×3 matrix. Hunt for zeros again! Column 2 is `0, -2, 0`. Expand along this new Column 2.
   - The only non-zero entry is -2.
   - The sign for position $(2,2)$ in a 3×3 matrix is $+$ (since $(-1)^{2+2} = +1$).
   - Cross out Row 2 and Column 2 to get the 2×2 minor.

$$\det(A) = +1 \cdot \left(+(-2) \begin{vmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ 2 & 1 \end{vmatrix} \right) = -2 \begin{vmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ 2 & 1 \end{vmatrix}$$

3. **Step 3:** Evaluate the final 2×2 determinant using $ad - bc$.

$$\det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix} = (1)(1) - (-1)(2) = 1 + 2 = 3$$

Multiply by the scalar we pulled out:

$$\det(A) = -2 \cdot 3 = -6$$

(By hunting for zeros, we solved a 4×4 matrix by calculating only a single 2×2 determinant, completely avoiding the dozens of sub-determinants we would have otherwise had to compute!)

Determinants of Triangular Matrices

A square matrix with a solid block of zeros on one side of the main diagonal is called a **triangular matrix**. There are two types:

- **Lower Triangular:** All entries *above* the main diagonal are zero.
- **Upper Triangular:** All entries *below* the main diagonal are zero. (Note: Every matrix in Row-Echelon Form is upper triangular since it naturally has zeros below the pivots!)
- *(Note: Diagonal matrices, like the Identity matrix I, are both upper and lower triangular at the same time).*

Finding the determinant of any triangular matrix is remarkably simple:

> **Theorem (Determinant of a Triangular Matrix)**
>
> $$\det(\text{triangular matrix}) = \text{product of its diagonal entries}$$
>
> Proof (Why?): This shortcut is a direct consequence of Theorem 2.1.1 (Cofactor Expansions). If you have a lower triangular matrix and you expand along the very first row, every single entry in that row is 0 *except* for the first diagonal entry a_{11}. As you continue the recursive expansion down the matrix, you

> keep getting 0s for every branch except the diagonal branch. The only surviving term at the end of the chain is $a_{11} \times a_{22} \times \cdots \times a_{nn}$.

The Adjoint Matrix ($Adj(A)$)

Definition (Matrix of Cofactors & Adjoint): If A is any $n \times n$ matrix and C_{ij} is the cofactor of a_{ij}, then the matrix formed by all these cofactors is called the **matrix of cofactors from** A:

$$\begin{bmatrix} C_{11} & C_{12} & \dots & C_{1n} \\ C_{21} & C_{22} & \dots & C_{2n} \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ C_{n1} & C_{n2} & \dots & C_{nn} \end{bmatrix}$$

The transpose of this matrix is called the **adjoint of** A and is denoted by $\text{adj}(A)$.

Property of Cofactor Expansions: As we know, multiplying the entries of a row by their *own* cofactors gives the determinant. However, if one multiplies the entries in any row by the corresponding cofactors from a **different** row, the sum of these products is **always zero**.

The generalized formula for the inverse of any square matrix A is:

$$A^{-1} = \frac{1}{\det(A)} \text{adj}(A)$$

(Recall from Section 4 that for a 2×2 matrix, $\text{adj}(A)$ is just swapping the main diagonal and flipping the signs of the off-diagonal: $\begin{bmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{bmatrix}$).

Worked Example: Adjoint of a 3×3 Matrix Let $A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 2 & -1 \\ 1 & 6 & 3 \\ 2 & -4 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$. If you calculate all 9 cofactors (using the $C_{ij} = (-1)^{i+j} M_{ij}$ formula and the checkerboard signs), you get the matrix of cofactors. Transposing that matrix yields:

$$\text{adj}(A) = \begin{bmatrix} 12 & 4 & 12 \\ 6 & 2 & -10 \\ -16 & 16 & 16 \end{bmatrix}$$

Geometric Intuition: Why the Inverse Formula Works

To truly understand the formula $A^{-1} = \frac{1}{\det(A)} \text{adj}(A)$, we must view a matrix geometrically as an **action**, rather than algebraically as a shelf of numbers.

A square matrix acts as a transformation that grabs points on a grid and moves them. The columns of the matrix dictate exactly where the original X-axis and Y-axis land. When a matrix transforms space, it can do three things:

1. **Stretch/Squish** (Changing the area/volume).
2. **Rotate** (Spinning the grid).
3. **Skew** (Tilting the axes so they are no longer perpendicular).

The Reversal Machine (A^{-1}) To find the inverse, we must perfectly reverse all three of these actions. The formula splits this into two elegant jobs:

- **The Un-Stretching:** The determinant ($\det(A)$) tells us exactly how much the original matrix multiplied the area of the grid. If $\det(A) = 3$, the area tripled. To reverse this, we must shrink everything back down by 3. This is why the formula scales the matrix by multiplying by $\frac{1}{\det(A)}$.
- **The Un-Skewing & Un-Rotating:** The Adjoint ($\text{adj}(A)$) is built directly out of the "footprints" (the cofactors) of where the axes originally landed. By using these coordinates to map a path backward, the Adjoint inherently restores the axes back to their perfect, un-rotated 90° orientation.

$$A^{-1} = [\text{Un-stretch the Area}] \times [\text{Un-rotate and Un-skew}]$$

$$A^{-1} = \left[\frac{1}{\det(A)}\right] \text{adj}(A)$$

(Note: If a matrix crushes the 2D grid completely flat into a 1D line, the area becomes 0. Because thousands of points get smashed together into the same line, the transformation cannot be reversed. This perfectly explains why a matrix with $\det(A) = 0$ has no inverse!)

---

9. Vectors in 2D & 3D (Refresher)

This section serves as a refresher on vector geometry from Calculus II, establishing the toolkit needed before defining formal Vector Spaces.

Vector Basics & Length

- **What is a Vector?** A quantity completely determined by magnitude (length) and direction. It is represented geometrically as a directed line segment (an arrow).
- **Scalars (k):** A scalar is just a regular, everyday real number (like 5, -2, or 0.5). Its only job is to *scale* a vector.
  - *Note on Absolute Value:* The formula $|k| = -k$ if $k < 0$ is just a mathematical instruction for "flip the sign to make it positive." When you multiply a vector $\vec{v}$ by a negative scalar (e.g., $k = -2$), the negative sign flips the arrow's direction 180°, and the absolute value $|-2| = 2$ tells you to stretch its length by 2.
- **The Norm (Length):** The length of a vector $\vec{v} = \langle x, y, z \rangle$ is denoted by double bars $||\vec{v}||$ and is a direct 3D generalization of the Pythagorean theorem:

$$||\vec{v}|| = \sqrt{x^2 + y^2 + z^2}$$

- **Unit Vectors:** A vector with a length of exactly 1 ($||\vec{v}|| = 1$). The standard unit vectors along the 3D axes are $\hat{i} = \langle 1, 0, 0 \rangle$, $\hat{j} = \langle 0, 1, 0 \rangle$, and $\hat{k} = \langle 0, 0, 1 \rangle$.

The Dot Product

The dot product (or Euclidean inner product) multiplies two vectors together to produce a **single scalar number** (not a vector). It encodes both length and the angle between the vectors.

- **Geometric Definition:**

$$\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v} = ||\vec{u}||\,||\vec{v}|| \cos(\theta)$$

- **Algebraic (Component) Formula:**

$$\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v} = u_1v_1 + u_2v_2 + u_3v_3$$

- **Dot Product with Itself:**

$$\vec{u} \cdot \vec{u} = ||\vec{u}||^2$$

- **Orthogonality (Perpendicularity):** Two vectors are orthogonal (perpendicular) if and only if the angle between them is 90°. Because $\cos(90^\circ) = 0$, their dot product evaluates exactly to zero:

$$\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v} = 0 \iff \vec{u} \perp \vec{v}$$

Projections (Splitting a Vector)

Often, we need to decompose a vector $\vec{u}$ into two perpendicular pieces: one pointing along a chosen direction $\vec{a}$, and one pointing perfectly perpendicular to $\vec{a}$.

> ### Theorem 3.3.3 (The Projection Theorem)
>
> If $\vec{u}$ and $\vec{a}$ are vectors and $\vec{a} \neq \mathbf{0}$, then $\vec{u}$ can be expressed in exactly one way as:
>
> $$\vec{u} = \vec{w}_1 + \vec{w}_2$$
>
> Where $\vec{w}_1$ is a scalar multiple of $\vec{a}$ (the projection), and $\vec{w}_2$ is orthogonal to $\vec{a}$.
>
> $$\vec{w}_1 = \text{proj}_{\vec{a}}\vec{u} = \frac{\vec{u} \cdot \vec{a}}{||\vec{a}||^2}\vec{a}$$

Intuition Behind the Formula: Think of calculating an x-component in 2D physics using $||\vec{u}|| \cos(\theta)$. The projection theorem is just the 3D "universal" version of that, allowing you to tilt your axis to any random vector $\vec{a}$.

1. **The Length (The Shadow):** Using the geometric dot product formula, we can isolate $||\vec{u}|| \cos(\theta)$ to find the exact length of the shadow $\vec{u}$ casts onto $\vec{a}$:

$$||\vec{u}|| \cos(\theta) = \frac{\vec{u} \cdot \vec{a}}{||\vec{a}||}$$

2. **The Direction:** To force our scalar length to point in the correct direction without changing its size, we multiply it by the unit vector of $\vec{a}$, which is $\frac{\vec{a}}{||\vec{a}||}$.
3. **The Result:** Multiplying the Length by the Direction gives:

$$\left(\frac{\vec{u} \cdot \vec{a}}{||\vec{a}||}\right)\left(\frac{\vec{a}}{||\vec{a}||}\right) = \left(\frac{\vec{u} \cdot \vec{a}}{||\vec{a}||^2}\right)\vec{a}$$

The Orthogonal Component ($\vec{w}_2$): In 2D physics, finding the vertical component is easy ($||\vec{u}|| \sin(\theta)$) because there is only one "up" direction. In 3D space, there is a full 360° disk of directions perpendicular to $\vec{a}$. To bypass nightmare 3D trigonometry, we use a simple vector addition shortcut. Since walking along the shadow ($\vec{w}_1$) and then straight up the vertical piece ($\vec{w}_2$) gets you to the exact same destination as the original vector ($\vec{u}$), we know $\vec{w}_1 + \vec{w}_2 = \vec{u}$. By rearranging this algebraically, we get the orthogonal component instantly:

$$\vec{w}_2 = \vec{u} - \text{proj}_{\vec{a}}\vec{u}$$

Direction Cosines

To perfectly describe a 3D direction without a full spherical coordinate system, we measure the angles the vector makes with the three axes: α (with the x-axis), β (with the y-axis), and γ (with the z-axis). Using basic right-triangle trigonometry ($SOHCAHTOA$), the cosines of these angles are exactly the vector's coordinates divided by its total length (the hypotenuse):

$$\cos\alpha = \frac{x}{||\vec{v}||}, \quad \cos\beta = \frac{y}{||\vec{v}||}, \quad \cos\gamma = \frac{z}{||\vec{v}||}$$

- **The Magic Identity:** Because of the 3D Pythagorean theorem ($x^2 + y^2 + z^2 = ||\vec{v}||^2$), squaring and adding these three cosines will always equal exactly 1:

$$\cos^2\alpha + \cos^2\beta + \cos^2\gamma = 1$$

- **The Takeaway:** The vector formed by these cosines $\langle \cos\alpha, \cos\beta, \cos\gamma \rangle$ is simply the **Unit Vector** pointing in the exact same direction as $\vec{v}$.

---

10. Euclidean n-Space ($\mathbb{R}^n$)

While 2D and 3D vectors map perfectly to physical space, mathematics allows us to generalize vectors to any number of dimensions (n).

- **n-tuples:** If n is a positive integer, an **ordered n-tuple** is a sequence of n real numbers $(x_1, x_2, \ldots, x_n)$.
- $\mathbb{R}^n$ **(n-space):** The set of all such n-tuples is called n-space, denoted by $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$ behave exactly identically to 2D and 3D vectors. Addition, scalar multiplication, and even geometric concepts like length and angles all still apply.

The Euclidean Inner Product (Dot Product)

The dot product scales up infinitely. In $\mathbb{R}^n$, it is called the **Euclidean Inner Product**. If $\vec{u} = \langle u_1, u_2, \ldots, u_n \rangle$ and $\vec{v} = \langle v_1, v_2, \ldots, v_n \rangle$, then:

$$\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v} = u_1v_1 + u_2v_2 + \cdots + u_nv_n$$

> **Theorem 4.1.2 (Properties of Euclidean Inner Product)**
>
> If $\vec{u}, \vec{v}, \vec{w}$ are vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$ and k is a scalar:
>
> - **(a) Symmetry:** $\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v} = \vec{v} \cdot \vec{u}$
> - **(b) Distributivity:** $(\vec{u} + \vec{v}) \cdot \vec{w} = \vec{u} \cdot \vec{w} + \vec{v} \cdot \vec{w}$
> - **(c) Homogeneity:** $(k\vec{u}) \cdot \vec{v} = k(\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v})$
> - **(d) Positivity:** $\vec{v} \cdot \vec{v} \geq 0$, and $\vec{v} \cdot \vec{v} = 0 \iff \vec{v} = \mathbf{0}$

> **Theorem 4.1.3 (Cauchy-Schwarz Inequality in $\mathbb{R}^n$)**
>
> The absolute value of a dot product can never exceed the product of the vectors' lengths.
>
> $$|\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v}| \leq ||\vec{u}||\,||\vec{v}||$$

Norm and Distance in $\mathbb{R}^n$

The Pythagorean theorem and the distance formula scale up directly by adding more terms under the square root.

- **Euclidean Norm (Length):** $||\vec{u}|| = \sqrt{u_1^2 + u_2^2 + \cdots + u_n^2}$
- **Euclidean Distance:** $d(\vec{u}, \vec{v}) = ||\vec{u} - \vec{v}|| = \sqrt{(u_1 - v_1)^2 + \cdots + (u_n - v_n)^2}$

> **Theorem 4.1.4 (Properties of Length in $\mathbb{R}^n$)**
>
> - **(a)** $||\vec{u}|| \geq 0$
> - **(b)** $||\vec{u}|| = 0 \iff \vec{u} = \mathbf{0}$
> - **(c)** $||k\vec{u}|| = |k|\,||\vec{u}||$
> - **(d) Triangle Inequality:** $||\vec{u} + \vec{v}|| \leq ||\vec{u}|| + ||\vec{v}||$

Proof **(c) (Scaling Length):**

$$||k\vec{u}|| = \sqrt{(ku_1)^2 + (ku_2)^2 + \cdots + (ku_n)^2}$$

$$= \sqrt{k^2(u_1^2 + u_2^2 + \cdots + u_n^2)}$$

$$= |k|\sqrt{u_1^2 + u_2^2 + \cdots + u_n^2} = |k|\,||\vec{u}||$$

Proof **(d) (Triangle Inequality):** We start with the golden rule that squared length equals the dot product with itself:

$$||\vec{u} + \vec{v}||^2 = (\vec{u} + \vec{v}) \cdot (\vec{u} + \vec{v})$$

$$= ||\vec{u}||^2 + 2(\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v}) + ||\vec{v}||^2$$

Since any number is $\leq$ its absolute value, we replace the middle term:

$$\leq ||\vec{u}||^2 + 2|\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v}| + ||\vec{v}||^2$$

Apply the Cauchy-Schwarz Inequality ($|\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v}| \leq ||\vec{u}||\,||\vec{v}||$):

$$\leq ||\vec{u}||^2 + 2||\vec{u}||\,||\vec{v}|| + ||\vec{v}||^2$$

Factor the perfect square:

$$\leq (||\vec{u}|| + ||\vec{v}||)^2$$

Taking the square root of both sides yields $||\vec{u} + \vec{v}|| \leq ||\vec{u}|| + ||\vec{v}||$.

> **Theorem 4.1.5 (Properties of Distance in $\mathbb{R}^n$)**
>
> Distance shares similar logical rules to length.
>
> - **(a)** $d(\vec{u}, \vec{v}) \geq 0$
> - **(b)** $d(\vec{u}, \vec{v}) = 0 \iff \vec{u} = \vec{v}$
> - **(c) Symmetry:** $d(\vec{u}, \vec{v}) = d(\vec{v}, \vec{u})$
> - **(d) Triangle Inequality:** $d(\vec{u}, \vec{v}) \leq d(\vec{u}, \vec{w}) + d(\vec{w}, \vec{v})$ (Taking a detour through $\vec{w}$ is always longer or equal to going straight).

Orthogonality & The Pythagorean Theorem

Even in hyperspace, we can determine if two vectors are perfectly perpendicular. **Definition:** Two vectors $\vec{u}$ and $\vec{v}$ in $\mathbb{R}^n$ are **orthogonal** if $\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v} = 0$.

> **Theorem 4.1.7 (Pythagorean Theorem in $\mathbb{R}^n$)**
>
> If $\vec{u}$ and $\vec{v}$ are orthogonal vectors, then:
>
> $$||\vec{u} + \vec{v}||^2 = ||\vec{u}||^2 + ||\vec{v}||^2$$

Proof **:**

$$||\vec{u} + \vec{v}||^2 = (\vec{u} + \vec{v}) \cdot (\vec{u} + \vec{v})$$
$$= ||\vec{u}||^2 + 2(\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v}) + ||\vec{v}||^2$$

Since the vectors are orthogonal, $\vec{u} \cdot \vec{v} = 0$. The middle term vanishes.

$$= ||\vec{u}||^2 + 0 + ||\vec{v}||^2 = ||\vec{u}||^2 + ||\vec{v}||^2$$

---

11. General Vector Spaces

We now shift to a much broader definition of vectors: **"Vector" is a job title.** If a set of objects (which could be matrices, functions, polynomials, or arrows) has a sensible "addition" and "scalar multiplication" that behave exactly as we expect them to, we call that set a **Vector Space**, and we refer to its elements as **vectors**.

The 10 Axioms of a Vector Space

Let V be a set of objects. V is a vector space if all 10 of these axioms hold for all vectors $\vec{u}, \vec{v}, \vec{w}$ in V and all scalars k, l:

The "Vegas" Rules (Closure):

1. **Closure under Addition:** $\vec{u} + \vec{v}$ is in V.
2. **Closure under Scalar Multiplication:** $k\vec{u}$ is in V. *(If operations pull you outside the set, it is not a vector space).*

The "Undo" Rules (Identities): 4. **Zero Vector:** There is a $\mathbf{0}$ in V such that $\vec{u} + \mathbf{0} = \vec{u}$. *(This implies a vector space is never empty).* 5. **Negative Vector:** Every $\vec{u}$ has an inverse $-\vec{u}$ such that $\vec{u} + (-\vec{u}) = \mathbf{0}$.

The Arithmetic Rules: 2. **Commutative:** $\vec{u} + \vec{v} = \vec{v} + \vec{u}$ 3. **Associative (Addition):** $\vec{u} + (\vec{v} + \vec{w}) = (\vec{u} + \vec{v}) + \vec{w}$ 7. **Distributive (Scalar over Vector Add):** $k(\vec{u} + \vec{v}) = k\vec{u} + k\vec{v}$ 8. **Distributive (Scalar Add over Vector):** $(k + l)\vec{u} = k\vec{u} + l\vec{u}$ 9. **Associative (Scalar Multiplication):** $k(l\vec{u}) = (kl)\vec{u}$ 10. **Scalar Identity:** $1\vec{u} = \vec{u}$

Proving vs. Disproving a Vector Space

- **To Prove:** You must systematically show that all 10 axioms hold true. (Most fall out directly from real-number arithmetic applied entrywise, like showing all 2×2 matrices form a vector space).
- **To Disprove:** You only need to find **one** axiom that fails.

- *Tip:* Always check Axiom 1 (Closure under addition) and Axiom 6 (Closure under scalar multiplication) first. They kill more failed candidates than any other axiom.

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12. Cramer's Rule

Cramer's Rule is a method for solving a system of linear equations using *only determinants*, completely bypassing Row Reduction (RREF) or calculating the full inverse matrix. It is extremely useful when you only need to solve for one specific variable in a system.

> **Theorem (Cramer's Rule)**
>
> If $Ax = b$ is a system of n linear equations in n unknowns such that $\det(A) \neq 0$, then the system has a unique solution. This solution is:
>
> $$x_1 = \frac{\det(A_1)}{\det(A)}, \quad x_2 = \frac{\det(A_2)}{\det(A)}, \quad \dots, \quad x_n = \frac{\det(A_n)}{\det(A)}$$
>
> where A_j is the matrix obtained by replacing the entries in the j-th column of A by the entries in the answer matrix b.

> [!NOTE] Not Part of Syllabus The following proof is not required for the exam, but it is an extremely elegant mathematical trick that is highly interesting to look at.

Proof: The mathematical proof of Cramer's Rule relies on a brilliant "Trojan Horse" trick using properties of determinants and the identity matrix.

Step 1: The Setup Consider the system $Ax = B$. If A is invertible (meaning $\det(A) \neq 0$), we know the unique solution is:

$$x = A^{-1}B$$

We also know that $A^{-1}A = I_n$. If we break the identity matrix into its column vectors $[e_1|e_2|\dots|e_n]$, we can write:

$$A^{-1}[c_1|c_2|\dots|c_n] = [e_1|e_2|\dots|e_n]$$

This means that for any column k, $A^{-1}c_k = e_k$.

Step 2: The "Trojan Horse" Matrix (D_k) We construct a new matrix called D_k. This matrix is identical to the Identity matrix I_n, except we replace the k-th column with our solution vector x:

$$D_k = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & \dots & x_1 & \dots & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & \dots & x_2 & \dots & 0 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots & & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \dots & x_n & \dots & 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

If we calculate the determinant of D_k by expanding along the k-th row, every entry is 0 except for x_k, and its minor is simply I_{n-1}. Therefore:

$$\det(D_k) = x_k \quad \text{— (Equation 1)}$$

Step 3: Factoring out A^{-1} Let's rewrite the columns of D_k using our knowledge from Step 1 ($e_k = A^{-1}c_k$) and our solution equation ($x = A^{-1}B$):

$$D_k = [A^{-1}c_1 | \dots | A^{-1}c_{k-1} | A^{-1}B | A^{-1}c_{k+1} | \dots | A^{-1}c_n]$$

We can factor out the A^{-1} matrix from every column:

$$D_k = A^{-1}[c_1 | \dots | c_{k-1} | B | c_{k+1} | \dots | c_n]$$

Step 4: The Reveal Look closely at the matrix left inside the brackets. It is exactly the original matrix A, but with the k-th column replaced by the answer vector B. By definition, this is exactly the matrix A_k from Cramer's Rule! Therefore:

$$D_k = A^{-1}A_k$$

Step 5: The Final Determinant Take the determinant of both sides using the multiplicative property ($\det(AB) = \det(A)\det(B)$):

$$\det(D_k) = \det(A^{-1}A_k)$$

$$\det(D_k) = \det(A^{-1})\det(A_k)$$

Since $\det(A^{-1}) = \frac{1}{\det(A)}$, this becomes:

$$\det(D_k) = \frac{\det(A_k)}{\det(A)} \quad \text{— (Equation 2)}$$

By combining Equation 1 ($\det(D_k) = x_k$) and Equation 2, we arrive at Cramer's Rule:

$$x_k = \frac{\det(A_k)}{\det(A)}$$

---

13. LU Decomposition

LU Decomposition is essentially the matrix form of Gaussian Elimination. It is a method of taking a square matrix A and factoring it into two separate matrices:

$$A = LU$$

- L **(Lower Triangular):** A lower triangular matrix with 1s down the main diagonal. This matrix acts as a "memory bank" that records all the row operations you performed.
- U **(Upper Triangular):** An upper triangular matrix. This is exactly the Row-Echelon Form of matrix A.

The Advantage: If you need to solve $Ax = b$ for several *different* target vectors (b), standard Gaussian Elimination forces you to augment the matrix $[A|b]$ and do all the row operations from scratch every single time the b changes. By decomposing A into L and U once, you can reuse them to instantly solve for any future b vectors without ever needing to recalculate the row operations.

Conditions for LU Decomposition

Plain LU decomposition is only possible under one strict condition:

- **No Row Swaps Allowed:** You must be able to reduce A to Row-Echelon form (U) *without ever interchanging any rows*. If you hit a 0 pivot and are forced to swap rows to keep going, plain LU decomposition fails for that matrix.

The Shortcut Method: Build L While You Build U

You do not need a separate pass to find L. You can pull it out "for free" while you perform Gaussian Elimination to find U.

1. **Reduce A to U:** Use standard Gaussian Elimination, but remember the golden rule: *no row swaps allowed*.
2. **Use Only Row Additions:** To eliminate an entry below the pivot, always use an operation in the form: $R_i \to R_i - m_{ij}R_j$.
3. **Drop into L:** Every time you perform that operation to kill an entry, take the multiplier you used (m_{ij}) and drop it directly into matrix L at the exact same position (i, j).
    - *(Shortcut logic: Just drop the **opposite** of whatever you added to the row into the L matrix).*
4. **Finish L:** Place \$1\$s down the entire main diagonal of L, and \$0\$s everywhere above the diagonal.

Worked Example: Let $A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 4 & -3 \\ -2 & 8 & 5 \\ 3 & 4 & 7 \end{bmatrix}$. We will reduce it to U and build L simultaneously.

- **Op 1:** Clear the -2 in position $(2, 1)$.
    - Operation: $R_2 \to R_2 + 2R_1$.
    - The opposite of $+2$ is -2. Drop -2 into L_{21}.
- **Op 2:** Clear the 3 in position $(3, 1)$.
    - Operation: $R_3 \to R_3 - 3R_1$.
    - The opposite of -3 is $+3$. Drop $+3$ into L_{31}.
- **Op 3:** Clear the remaining number below the diagonal in position $(3, 2)$.
    - Operation: $R_3 \to R_3 + \frac{1}{2}R_2$.
    - The opposite of $+\frac{1}{2}$ is $-\frac{1}{2}$. Drop -0.5 into L_{32}.

Your U matrix is the result of those operations:

$$U = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 4 & -3 \\ 0 & 16 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & 15.5 \end{bmatrix}$$

Your L matrix is built from the opposites, with \$1\$s on the diagonal:

$$L = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ \mathbf{-2} & 1 & 0 \\ \mathbf{3} & \mathbf{-0.5} & 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

How to Solve $Ax = b$ using LU Decomposition

Once you have factored A into L and U, you solve the system in two incredibly fast steps using a "middleman" vector called y. Since $A = LU$, the equation $Ax = b$ becomes $LUx = b$. We group Ux together and define it as y (so $Ux = y$). This leaves us with $Ly = b$.

- **Step 1: Solve $Ly = b$ (Forward Substitution)** Because L is a lower triangular matrix, the very first equation only has one variable! You instantly find y_1, plug it into the second equation to find y_2, and work your way *downwards* to find the entire vector y.
- **Step 2: Solve $Ux = y$ (Backward Substitution)** Now take your newly found y vector and set it equal to Ux. Because U is an upper triangular matrix (Row-Echelon form), the very last equation only has one variable. You instantly find x_n, and work your way *upwards* to find the entire vector x, which is your final answer!

(The beauty of this method is that neither step requires row reduction—they just require simple algebraic substitution!)

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14. Vocabulary Glossary

Here is a master list of all the terminology introduced in this document:

- **Linear Equation:** An equation where all variables are to the first power, and there are no products of variables or special functions.
- **System of Linear Equations:** A set of multiple linear equations evaluated together.
- **Consistent System:** A system that has at least one valid solution.
- **Inconsistent System:** A system that has absolutely no valid solutions.
- **Homogeneous System:** A system where all equations equal exactly zero ($Ax = 0$).
- **Trivial Solution:** The guaranteed solution $x = 0$ in a homogeneous system.
- **Matrix:** A rectangular array of numbers.
- **Order of a Matrix:** The size of the matrix, read as Rows $\times$ Columns.
- **Zero (Null) Matrix (O):** A matrix where every single entry is 0.
- **Diagonal Matrix:** A square matrix where every entry *off* the main diagonal is zero.
- **Identity Matrix (I):** A diagonal matrix populated entirely with 1s on the main diagonal. Acts as the number "1" for matrices.
- **Transpose (A^T):** The operation of flipping a matrix's rows and columns over its main diagonal.
- **Symmetric Matrix:** A square matrix that perfectly equals its own transpose ($A = A^T$).
- **Skew-Symmetric Matrix:** A square matrix that equals the negative of its own transpose ($A = -A^T$). The main diagonal must be all zeros.
- **Invertible (Nonsingular) Matrix:** A square matrix A that possesses a valid inverse matrix A^{-1}, meaning $AA^{-1} = I$.
- **Singular Matrix:** A square matrix that does not have an inverse.
- **Elementary Row Operations (EROs):** The three legal moves used to solve systems (Scaling a row, Swapping rows, or Adding a multiple of one row to another).
- **Elementary Matrix:** A matrix generated by applying exactly one ERO to the Identity matrix.
- **Row-Echelon Form (REF):** A stair-step matrix format where leading entries are 1, zeros are below the leading 1s, and rows of all zeros are at the bottom.
- **Reduced Row-Echelon Form (RREF):** The strictest matrix format. It meets all REF criteria, PLUS every leading 1 is the *only* non-zero number in its entire column.
- **Pivot (Leading 1):** The first non-zero number in a row of an REF or RREF matrix.
- **Free Variable:** A variable in a system whose corresponding matrix column does *not* contain a pivot.
- **Parametric Form:** The final format of equations where leading variables are defined in terms of free variables.